Jointly Owned, Beneficiary, Transfer on Death

The words on Mom's statements and policies, and what to note about each.

You and Mom sit down with her statements, and by the second page you're both guessing at what some of the words mean. These are the words you're most likely to meet, each with one plain line, taken from a public source wherever one defines it, and what to write down when you see it.

The lines are for reading the paper in front of you. They aren't for working out what any of it means for Medicaid. That depends on the state and on Mom's situation.

Income

Social Security payment

A regular benefit payment. A federal overview lists Social Security retirement or disability payments among the kinds of income. [1]

WRITE DOWN The amount as printed, and where the letter or statement is kept.

Interest and dividends

Income from accounts and investments: interest from bank accounts and certificates of deposit, and dividends from stocks and bonds. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which accounts pay them, and where those statements are kept.

Pension

Another kind of income on the same federal list. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau counts pension and other retirement benefit summaries among the papers most relevant to a person's finances. [1] [2]

WRITE DOWN Who pays it, the amount as printed, and where the benefit summary is.

Annuity

A contract in which a person gives an insurance company money that is later distributed back to the person over time. [3]

WRITE DOWN The company, where the contract is kept, and whether payments have started.

Accounts and bills

Bank and brokerage statements

Among the papers the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau calls most relevant to a person's finances. It suggests keeping recent ones available. [2]

WRITE DOWN The institution, the kind of account, and where the latest statement is.

Automatic payments

Bills that are automatically withdrawn from a checking account or charged to a credit card. AARP suggests noting which ones they are. [5]

WRITE DOWN Each one, what it pays for, and the account or card it comes from.

Retirement accounts (IRA, 401(k))

A line on the Family Caregiver Alliance's papers form. How the kinds differ is a question for a licensed financial professional. [4]

WRITE DOWN Each account, the company that holds it, and where the latest statement is.

Debts and regular payments

What Mom owes and pays on a schedule. The bureau suggests a list with the names of the institutions that issued the loans or credit cards. [2]

WRITE DOWN The lender or card company, and where the statements are kept.

Insurance and property

Long-term care insurance

An insurance policy designed to offer financial support to pay for long-term care services. Medicare.gov notes that these policies can vary widely. [3] [6]

WRITE DOWN The company, where the policy is kept, and the agent's name if there is one.

Life insurance

A policy to list by company. AARP's questions for a parent include “Do you own life insurance?” [5]

WRITE DOWN The company, where the policy is kept, and the agent's name if there is one.

Titles and deeds

Papers the Family Caregiver Alliance's form lists alongside auto ownership records. AARP suggests asking where the titles or deeds and registration are for a vehicle, a boat or land. [4] [5]

WRITE DOWN Each property or vehicle, and where its deed, title or registration is kept.

Mortgage and home equity loan

Debts secured by the home, in the words of a federal overview. [1]

WRITE DOWN The lender, and where the latest statement is.

Whose name is on it

Jointly owned (a joint account)

An account where the money is jointly owned and, the bureau says, the joint account holder automatically gets the money when the other owner dies. [7]

WRITE DOWN The names exactly as printed on the statement.

Convenience account

Not the same as a joint account. The bureau says it does not change the ownership of the money in the account. [7]

WRITE DOWN If a second name is on an account, ask the bank which kind it is and note the answer.

Trust and trustee

A trustee makes decisions about money or property in a trust, and can manage only what is in the trust. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom has a trust, where the trust agreement is kept, and who the trustee is.

Beneficiary

A name an institution has on record for an account or policy. AARP suggests listing the accounts that have one and checking with each institution that its records reflect the owner's wishes. [8]

WRITE DOWN Which accounts and policies have one on record, as Mom or the institution tells you.

Transfer on death

An arrangement the roadmap lists under ownership, as something to note. The sources below don't define it, so what it means for an account or a property is a question for an elder law attorney or your Medicaid planner.

WRITE DOWN Which statement or record carries the words, copied exactly.

What this sheet doesn't do

It explains words in general terms. It doesn't say which of them apply to Mom, how anything she owns would be treated, or whether anything should change, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. Those questions go to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.

Ready for the next step?

You can read Mom's statements and policies now, and you know what to note. The planning interview asks about your family's situation in plain language and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Glossary
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Where to Find My Important Papers
5. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records
6. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
7. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Considering a financial caregiver? Know your options
8. AARP, Legal Checklist for Caregivers With Aging Parents

From the Medicaid Planning Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.